Replication Project

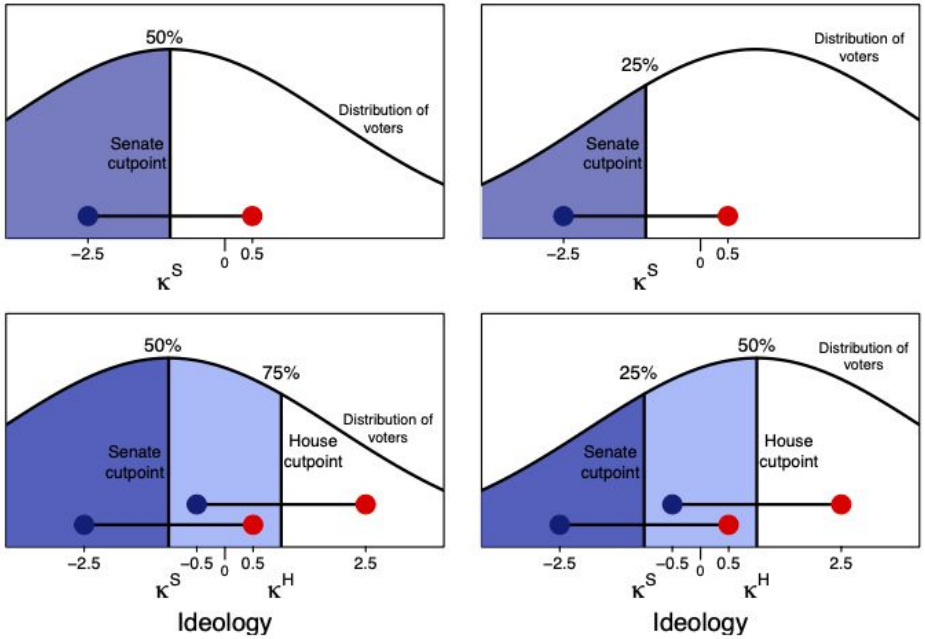
Ideological Moderation and Success in U.S. Elections, 2020-2022 by Michael A. Bailey and Benjamin F. Reese

Introduction

Median Voter Theory: “If voters vote based on ideology, the candidate who can win the support of the median ideological voter will win

Modeling

- Calculate vote shares as function of candidate idealogy
- Compare multiple races per geographical area



Democratic voteshare is a linear function of the district preferences and the cutpoints

$$
\begin{aligned}
DemPct_d^{House} &= \mu_d + \beta \frac{\theta_{D,d}^{House} + \theta_{R,d}^{House}}{2} \\
&= \mu_d + \beta \kappa_d^{House} \\
DemPct_d^{Senate} &= \mu_d + \beta \frac{\theta_{D,d}^{Senate} + \theta_{R,d}^{Senate}}{2} \\
&= \mu_d + \beta \kappa_d^{Senate}
\end{aligned}
$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
DemPct_d^{House} - DemPct_d^{Senate} &= \mu_d + \beta \kappa_d^{House} - \mu_d - \beta \kappa_d^{Senate} \\
\Delta_d^{House-Senate} &= \beta(\kappa_d^{House} - \kappa_d^{Senate})
\end{aligned}
$$

Various Controls and Confounding Variables

- Incumbency
- Demographics
- Valance (uncontrolled)

Data

Common Ideology measurements:

- Finance scores
- The Website Formerly Known As Twitter follower networks

Chosen path:

- “Wordfish” model
- Mixture of sources

Success!

Table 1: Predicting Republican congressional voting, 2022

Dependent Variable:	Legislative ideology 2022			
	All		New members	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
Contribution scores 2020	0.56*** (0.06)		0.48*** (0.13)	
Text scores 2020		0.74*** (0.04)		0.47*** (0.13)
Constant	-0.02 (0.06)	0.005 (0.04)	-0.01 (0.13)	1.5×10^{-16} (0.13)
Fit statistics				
Observations	206	230	46	47
R^2	0.33	0.56	0.23	0.22

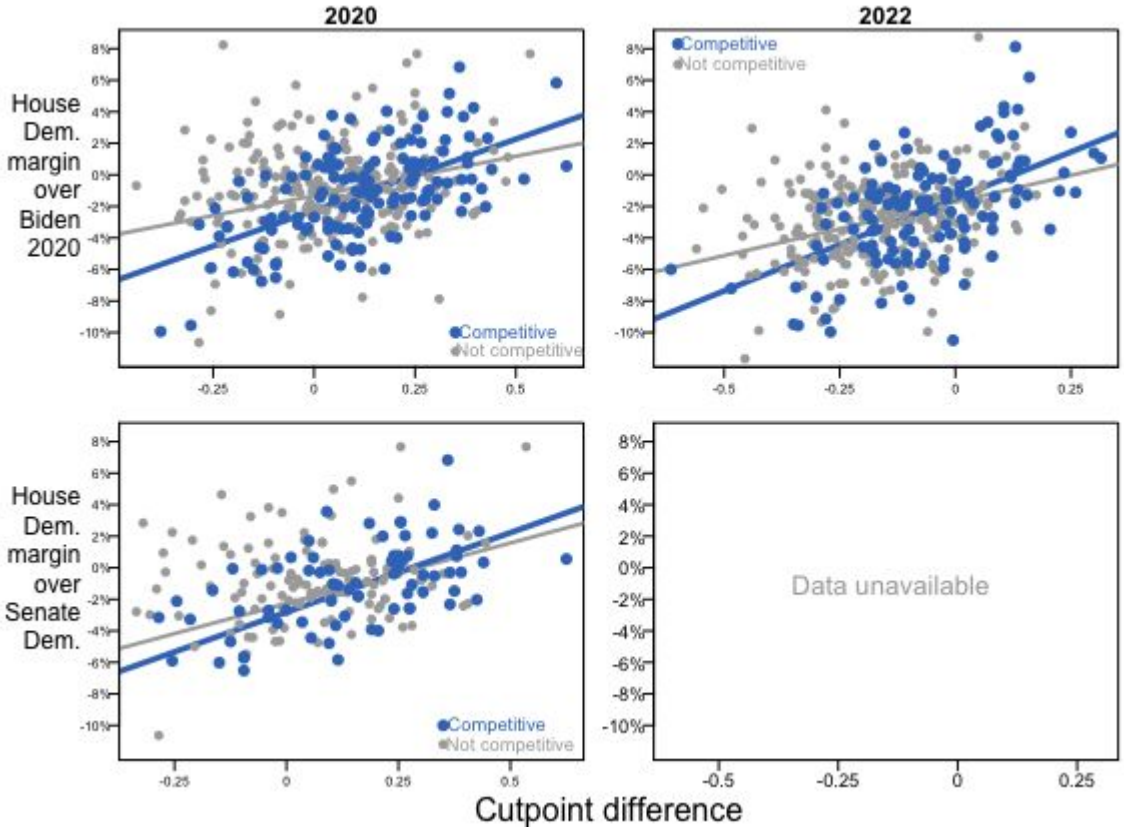
IID standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Table 2: Predicting Democratic congressional voting, 2022

Dependent Variable:	Legislative ideology 2022			
	All		New members	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
Contribution scores 2020	0.20*** (0.07)		0.37 (0.26)	
Text scores 2020		0.78*** (0.04)		0.80*** (0.14)
Constant	-0.06 (0.07)	-0.004 (0.04)	-0.01 (0.25)	2.5×10^{-17} (0.13)
Fit statistics				
Observations	193	229	17	21
R^2	0.04	0.60	0.12	0.64

IID standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Competitive Districts



How’d they do relative to biden?

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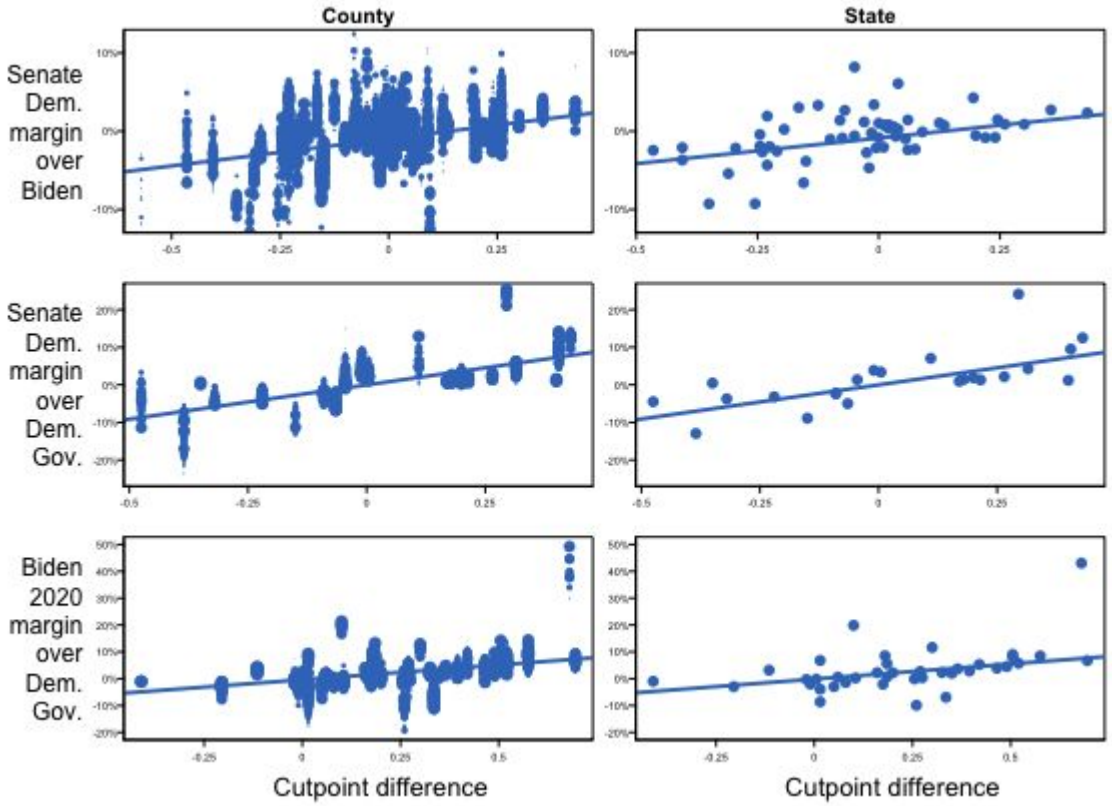


Conclusion

Democrats perform better when the dividing line is further to the right, republicans perform better when the dividing line is further to the left.

Variance depends on level of the race

Localized races have less impact

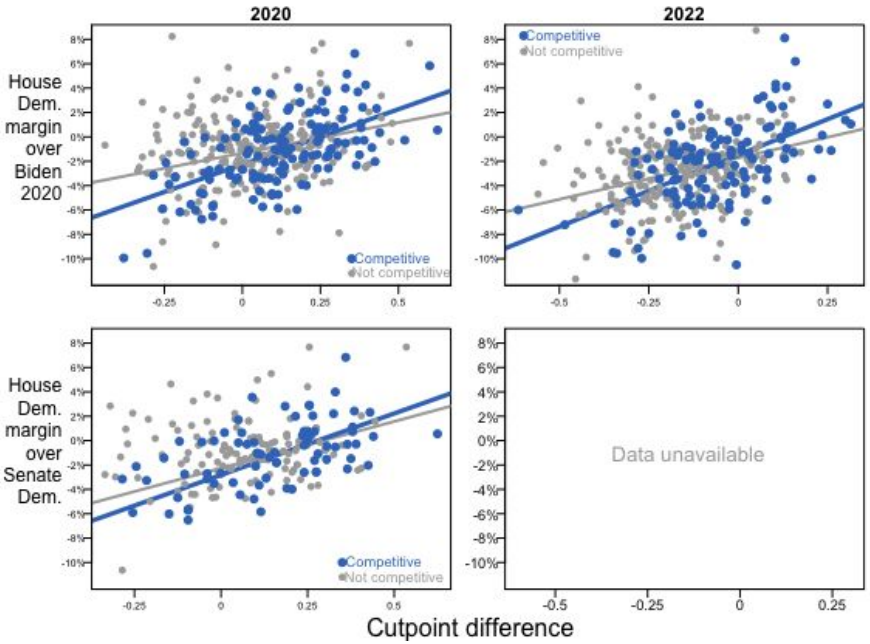
Additional Research

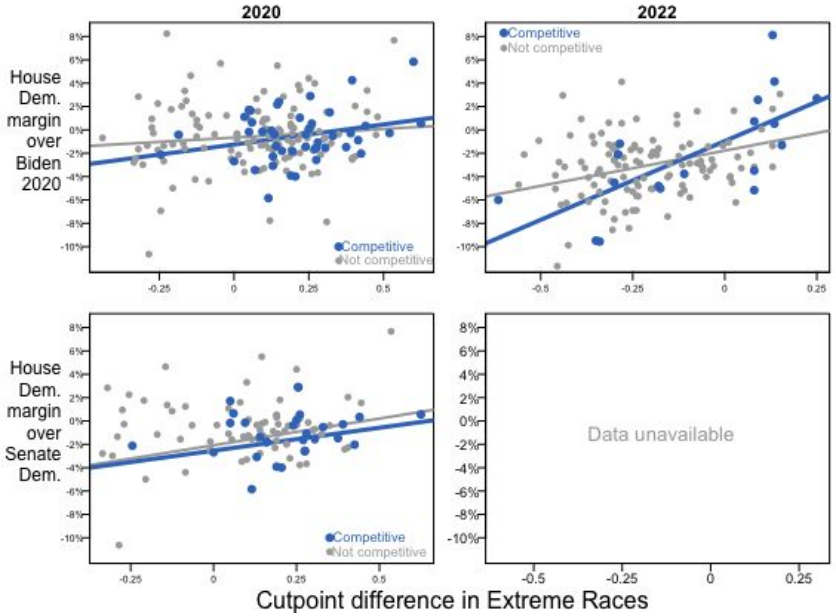
But what about extremist cases?

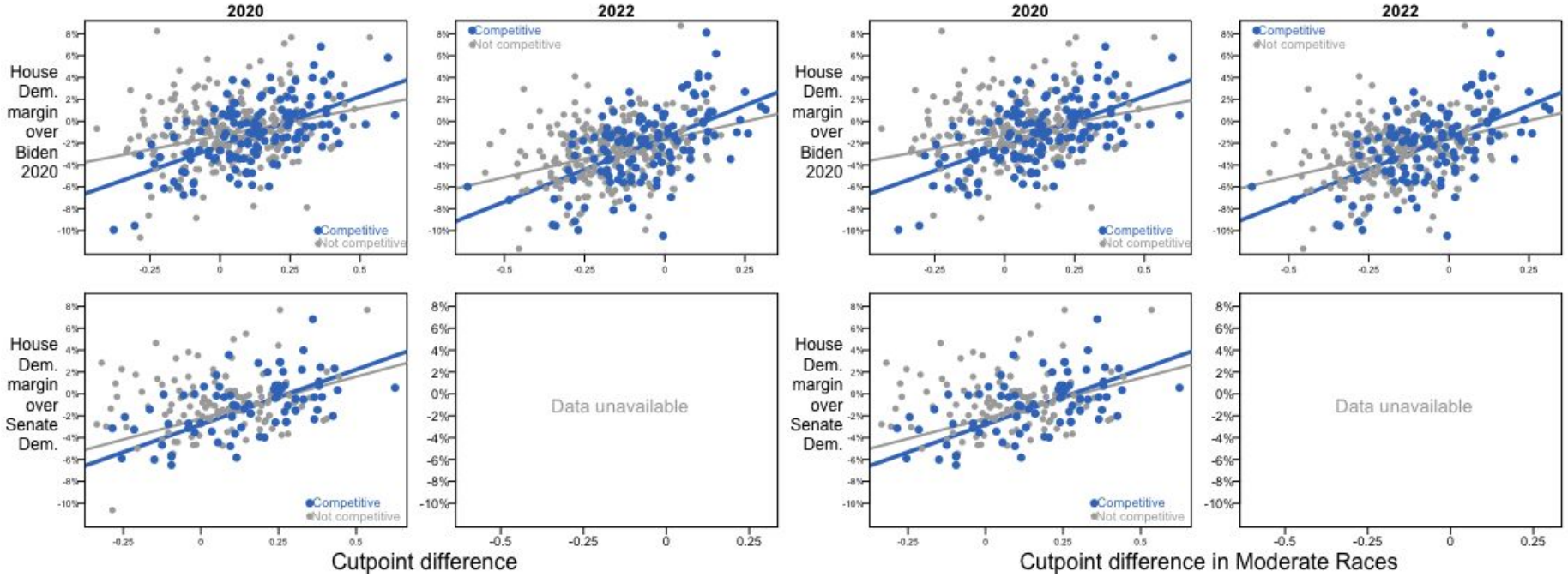
“Extremist” and “Moderate” Designation

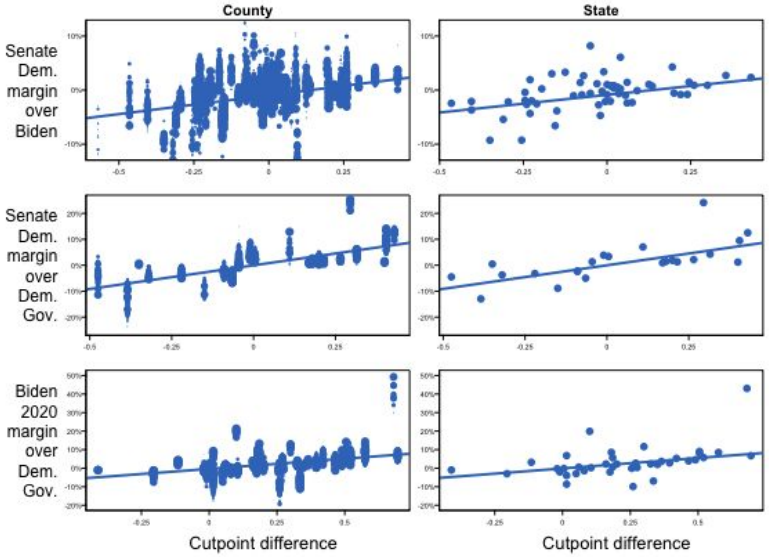
Anchors of -1.42 to 1.62

Looking at -1.2/1.2 as our “extremist” cutoff point.

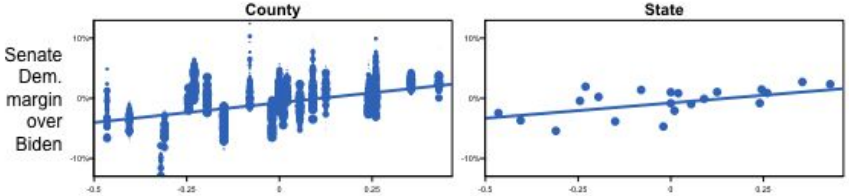

2020
2022
House Dem. margin over Biden 2020
House Dem. margin over Senate Dem.
Competitive
Not competitive
Data unavailable
Cutpoint difference


2020
2022
House Dem. margin over Biden 2020
House Dem. margin over Senate Dem.
Competitive
Not competitive
Data unavailable
Cutpoint difference in Extreme Races

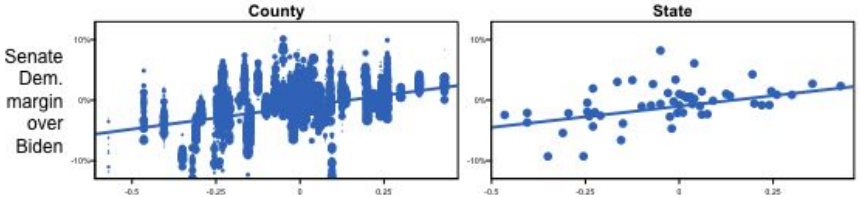

2020
2022
2020
2022
House Dem. margin over Biden 2020
House Dem. margin over Senate Dem.
Competitive
Not competitive
Data unavailable
Cutpoint difference
Cutpoint difference in Moderate Races



Extreme



Moderate



Conclusions

Competitive races are less extreme than uncompetitive races

House races performed meaningfully better, senate races unaffected.